

APM Project Management Qualification

Learner Study Pack



Team management

Introduction

This section of the Learner Study Pack will cover the Team Management competence of the APM Project Management Qualification.

This section will enable you to gain an understanding of team management as the process of managing a group of people working in collaboration or by cooperation towards a common goal.

Learning objective and outcomes

Learning objective:

13. Understand team management as the ability to work with team members to create and sustain teams.

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

13a) Know the different stages in the development of a team, including creation, development, maintenance and leadership, and understand the factors which influence these stages and knowledge of the models that are used to understand team development (such as Belbin, Margerison McCann, Myers-Briggs, Hackman, Tuckman, Katzenbach and Smith).

13b) Know the characteristics and benefits of effective teams and teamwork.

13c) Understand why different leadership approaches are needed to support virtual and hybrid teams.

Study time

This section of the Learner Study Pack will take approximately 1 - 2 hours to complete.

Recommended resources

In addition to your Learner Study Pack, use the below references for more information on Team Management:

- APM Body of Knowledge Seventh edition 3.2.3 (Team development)
- APM (2014) Team dimensions <https://www.apm.org.uk/blog/team-dimensions/>
- APM (2018) How leadership style affects team ownership? <https://www.apm.org.uk/blog/how-leadership-style-affects-team-ownership/>
- APM (2018) What Makes a High Performing Team? <https://www.apm.org.uk/news/what-makes-a-high-performing-team/>
- Belbin: The Nine Belbin Team Roles, Belbin Team Roles | Belbin

Overview

Team management is the art of guiding a group of individuals towards a common goal. It involves co-ordinating tasks, fostering collaboration, as well as understanding and leveraging the strengths of each of the individuals in the team.

Effective team management is essential for project success as it ensures a cohesive, motivated and performing workforce dynamic.

Team Development and Management Models

There are many team development and management models available, and the most useful ones explore the different stages in the development of a team as well as the key influencing factors.

Here are three models that show the factors to consider when examining team development:

- Belbin

This model shows roles that are optimal for an effective team.

Individuals tend to have roles that they are most comfortable with.

If the leader understands how everyone in the team tends to behave and contribute and where their strengths lie, they can develop the team by utilising these strengths and behaviours.

- Margerison McCann

This model is similar to Belbin and works on understanding an individual's preferred role within a team.

It explores how individuals relate to others, how they gather and use information, how they make decisions and how they organise themselves and others.

If the leader understands these aspects of each team member, then they can select the correct mix of complementary skills, to achieve a high performing team.

- Myers Briggs

This model recognises that how individuals perceive a situation, along with their communication preferences, will influence how they react to the situation.

It allows project team members to be integrated more easily into the project environment, aligning to values and therefore improves performance.

The leader can use this to influence perception or manage their reaction.

Stages of Team Development

Typically, there are different stages that teams move through, and it can be helpful to identify the applicable stage to ensure that the needs of that stage are met by the team's leaders.

Here are three models that explore the stages of team development:

- Hackman

This model suggests that five conditions need to be put in place and maintained by the leader for the team to be effective:

1. Team must be a real team, rather than a team in name only.

2. Direction of work must be clear.
3. Structure must support teamworking.
4. Organisation must be supportive.
5. Coaching available within the team.

□ Tuckman

This model recognises how a project team may take time to mature into a performing team and the leader should facilitate progression through the following stages of team development:

1. Forming - team members get acquainted with each other and individual working styles
2. Storming - conflicts may arise between team members
3. Norming - establishing and maintaining team cultural 'norms'
4. Performing - the team becomes fully productive

- Katzenbach and Smith

This model recognises that the more effective the group are as a team, the higher the performance.

Actions should be in place to ensure team members are clear on specific goals, that the right mix of skills is in place and accountabilities are clear.

The leader can support this by developing the level of commitment, accountability and the skills within the team.

What makes a team effective?

The characteristics of an effective team are:

- Clear roles and responsibilities aligned to skill and experience so that team members know what is expected of them.
- Open, clear and honest communication will build trust and confidence between the leader and the team as well as providing a platform for innovative discussion to take place.
- A common goal and sense of community led by the project manager will develop the common focus to deliver the outputs to achieve the goal.

What are the benefits of an effective team and teamwork?

The benefits of an effective team and teamwork are:

- Improved motivation through a sense of belonging and shared sense of accomplishment.
- Good problem solving through sharing of ideas, knowledge and experience to overcome challenges.
- Team members feel more confident to try new things, to be creative and innovative as a team rather than alone as there is a sense that the risk is shared.
- Increased productivity through sharing the workload and allocating tasks to match skill and experience.

Supporting Virtual and Hybrid Teams

Supporting virtual and hybrid teams involves embracing digital collaboration tools, fostering clear communication channels and promoting a sense of connection among team members.

Here are some of the ways that effective leadership can support virtual and hybrid teams to improved development and performance:

How leaders can enable trust to be established when teams are disparate and avoid hidden conflict

- Coordinate activities to help develop the trust.
- Hold regular team meetings allowing everyone to contribute.
- Create opportunities for team dialogue.
- Mixture of formal and informal meetings.
- IT solutions to collaborative online workspace e.g., chat options such as Microsoft Teams.

How leaders can overcome cultural differences

- Promote the right behaviours within the team & demonstrate an appreciation of cultural nuances and expectations.
- Encourage listening and sharing each other's perspectives.
- Give clear messages and promoting respect.
- Build a clear project team identity to help establish team norms of behaviour, and common values, across cultures.

How leaders can overcome challenges to open and synchronous communication

- Agree norms of communication to ensure that the same message can be understood by all the different members of the team.
- Acknowledge time zone differences and accommodate adaptations to messages to achieve a level of consistency.
- Use technology to overcome communication barriers.

How leaders can facilitate contribution of all team members

- Ensure team has the right training and tools to use the technology platforms which promote collaboration.
- Encourage equal virtual participation in virtual presence taking individual needs into account.
- Provide opportunities to collaborate outside of meetings, sharing information ahead of time, allowing questions via email.

Scenario One:

Lee, the HR Manager, in conjunction with external recruitment agencies has recently appointed a new Customer Services Team Leader who will be responsible for the ongoing management of the team, as well as guiding them through the transition to a hybrid working approach as part of the larger Snappy Appy renovation project.

Lee wants to ensure that the newly appointed Team Leader has all the support that they will need when they arrive and so wants to ensure that the senior leadership team have given some thought as to how to mitigate some of the challenges that face new teams.

As the new hybrid team structure forms part of the renovation project, Lee has asked you to help them identify potential challenges as well as suggest solutions that the new Team Leader could consider.

What are the key challenges to consider when creating an effective hybrid team made up of both onsite and remote members?

What steps could be taken to resolve these challenges?

Scenario Two:

The new Customer Services Team Leader has started their role and has emphasised the importance of improving the company's customer satisfaction scores.

However, sometimes change initiatives can be met with challenges and the team have hit their first.

There is a heated debate within the team about the best approach to handle customer complaints – some of the team advocate for a streamlined ticketing system that will allow all enquiries to be handled objectively and fairly depending on when they occurred, whereas others within the team believe that a more personalised approach should be adopted that takes into account the nature of the complaint and the existing relationship with the customer.

The new Team Leader has come to you for advice on possible solutions, especially due to your interaction with the Customer Services Team as part of the renovation project.

What steps could be taken to address the internal conflict in the team and foster better understanding moving forward?

What stage of Tuckman's model of Team Development do you think is typified by this internal conflict?

What is the potential impact of not addressing the conflicting ideas within the team?

Learning review questions

Before you attempt the exam practice questions in the next section, we recommend you review your learning to quickly see which aspects you don't understand or can't remember as well.

It will also boost your confidence by confirming what you have learnt and your demonstrated ability to apply that knowledge, so that you are ready to practise for the exam.

Here are some questions you may wish to answer to review your learning from the Team Management section:

- What are the key stages in team development according to Tuckman?
- What challenges might a team face during the storming stage and how can they be addressed?
- What is the significance of effective communication in team development?
- How can a leader foster trust within a team?
- What strategies can be used to enhance collaboration within a team?

Exam practice questions

13.1 In a software development company, a new project is underway to create an innovative mobile application.

The project team includes:

- Software developers
- User interface designers
- Marketing specialists

The team faces challenges such as an aggressive timescale, fast evolving technology, and varying priorities among several stakeholders

Which two of these methods would be the most appropriate for team cohesion?
(1 mark)

1. Establish a rigid hierarchy to streamline decision-making processes.
2. Encourage open communication channels, allowing team members to share their perspectives and ideas freely.
3. Divide team members into their distinct workstreams to avoid conflicts and distractions.
4. Focus attention on those that demonstrate advanced capabilities.
5. Assign tasks based solely on technical expertise to ensure efficiency.
6. Foster a collaborative environment where team members understand and appreciate each other's unique strengths and contributions.

Select the correct combination of methods:

- a. 1 & 3
- b. 2 & 6
- c. 3 & 4
- d. 5 & 6

13.2 The team you manage have recently moved to hybrid working to cut costs and encourage a better work life balance for team members. This has led to more flexible working, and the general feedback on the new arrangement is positive, however it has been difficult for some team members to adapt to the new way of working.

Which one of the following changes to your leadership approach would be effective in helping your team adapt to the new hybrid model?
(1 mark)

- a. Implement daily check-in meetings to manage performance. This will ensure the manager has complete oversight of their team.
- b. Encourage the team to work remotely as much as possible. This will increase savings and reduce the need for hybrid meetings which can be harder to run.
- c. Make the best use of the time in meetings by setting a standard agenda and making sure it's followed closely.
- d. Give the team freedom to manage their own time, but schedule regular in-person meetings to build rapport and check-in on team wellbeing.

13.3 You have taken on a new project in your organisation and have successfully recruited your team. Some of the team members are internal transfers, others are new to the company, however, none of the members have ever worked together in the past.

What are four stages of team development in Tuckman's model of team development?
(4 marks)

How is this model relevant to you in the above scenario?
(1 mark)

13.4 Describe one model that can be used to understand team development.
(2 marks)

13.5 It is common for teams to have at least one person who is working remotely from the others.

What are two challenges this could cause for you as a leader?
(2 marks)

13.6 In order for a project team to be as effective as possible, it's important that the team has _____**(a)**_____.

If a team has _____**(b)**_____, they will feel more confident to be innovative and creative when developing solutions.

(2 marks)

(a)

1. Regular face-to-face meetings
2. A shared sense of accountability
3. Close oversight by their manager
4. Responsibility for their own time

(b)

1. A hierarchical structure
2. Clear rewards
3. A focus on their own roles
4. Open and honest communication

Exam practice answers

Question	Answer / Mark Scheme
13.1	B
13.2	D
13.3	1 mark per each correct answer, 4 marks available in total; • Forming. • Storming. • Norming. • Performing. • Adjourning ? Mourning. 1 mark why the model is relevant in the scenario. For example, but not limited to: • It will give you an understanding that it can take a period of time for the team to adapt and find out how to work together. • It will reassure you that high performance cannot happen as soon as a new team is formed. • It will help you prepare for the future stages e.g. how to manage the storming phase. • It will help you know that if the team members leave or new members join, then the team can move back a phase.
13.4	1 mark for identifying a model: • Belbin. • Margerison-McCann, • Myers-Briggs. • Hackman. • Tuckman. • Katzenbach and Smith. 1 mark for describing the model: • Belbin explains the different roles that are optimal for an effective team / identifies what roles individuals can take on within a team / identifies an individual's preferred role within a team. • Margerison-McCann explores understanding an individual's preferred role within a team / covers how individuals work within a team. • Myers-Briggs includes how individuals perceive a situation, along with their communication preferences / identifies individual's personality types through four lenses / includes where individuals put their focus and attention, how they perceive information, how they make decisions and how they plan / structure their work / assesses four dimensions of extraversion vs introversion, sensing/intuition, thinking vs feeling, and judging vs perceiving. • Hackman suggests that five conditions need to be put in place for the team to be effective / includes five conditions for team effectiveness. • Tuckman recognises how a project team may take time to mature into a performing team / includes four stages of team development e.g. forming, storming, norming, performing. • Katzenbach and Smith recognises that the more effective the group are as a team, the higher the performance / has four key elements e.g. common purpose, goals, complementary skills and mutual accountability.
13.5	1 mark for each challenge identified, 2 marks available in total. For example: • More difficult to build deep relationships and trust virtually than in person. • Harder to detect first signs of conflict developing. • Harder to resolve conflict.

	• Harder to bond as a team when not seeing each other often and having informal conversations. • The team who isn't remote may feel disconnected from the one remote worker. • The remote worker may feel isolated.
13.6	(a) 2 (b) 4